Similarly, if companies in a misogynist society prefer to hire men rather than women, an algorithm trained on real-life data is likely to pick up that bias, too. This indeed happened when Amazon tried in 2014–18 to develop an algorithm for screening job applications. Learning from previous successful and unsuccessful applications, the algorithm began to systematically downgrade applications simply for containing the word 'women' or coming from graduates of women's colleges. Since existing data showed that in the past such applications had less chance of succeeding, the algorithm developed a bias against them. The algorithm thought it had simply discovered an objective truth about the world: applicants who graduate from women's colleges are less qualified. In fact, it just internalised and imposed a misogynist bias. Amazon tried and failed to fix the problem and ultimately scrapped the project.[64]

The database on which an AI is trained is a bit like a human's childhood. Childhood experiences, traumas and fairy tales stay with us throughout our lives. AIs too have childhood experiences. Algorithms might even infect one another with their biases, just as humans do. Consider a future society in which algorithms are ubiquitous and used not just to screen job applicants but also to recommend to people what to study in college. Suppose that due to a pre-existing misogynist bias, 80 per cent of jobs in engineering are given to men. In this society, an algorithm that hires new engineers is not only likely to copy this pre-existing bias but also to infect the college recommendation algorithms with the same bias. A young woman entering college may be discouraged from studying engineering, because the existing data indicates she is less likely to eventually get a job. What began as a human intersubjective myth that 'women aren't good at engineering' might morph into an inter-computer myth. If we don't get rid of the bias at the very beginning, computers may well perpetuate and magnify it.[65]

But getting rid of algorithmic bias might be as difficult as ridding ourselves of our human biases. Once an algorithm has been trained, it takes a lot of time and effort to 'untrain' it. We might decide to just dump the biased algorithm and train an altogether new algorithm on a new set of less biased data. But where on earth can we find a set of totally unbiased data?[66]

Many of the algorithmic biases surveyed in this and previous chapters share the same fundamental problem: the computer thinks it has discovered